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**Neurodivergent experiences in Communication Sciences and Disorders Programs as
reflected in Reddit**

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Abstract

By definition, neurodivergent students are those whose brain function differs significantly from societal expectations (Walker, 2014). The term 'neurodivergent' is associated with the Neurodiversity Movement. Although the Neurodiversity Movement was spearheaded by the Autistic¹ community, the term commonly includes other forms of neurodivergence such as ADHD and dyslexia. The purpose of this study was to explore the experiences of neurodivergent students in Communication Sciences Disorders (CSD) programs, where systematic data on their demographics and experience is relatively limited. Specifically, this study analysed posts from the online social media platform Reddit that are dedicated to the college experience of neurodivergent students in CSD. We searched channels related to the SLP using key search terms such as *neurodivergent* and *autistic*. Once collected and imported into software for qualitative analysis (Atlas.ti), thematic analysis was used to derive key inductive patterns. This research highlights the key themes that emerged from the analysis of the posts and their relative comments reflecting the experiences and challenges of neurodivergent individuals in CSD. These themes included challenges related to ableism, experiences with Applied Behavioural Sciences (ABA), navigating social interactions with peers and educators, and difficulties confirming neurotypical norms. The findings emphasize the importance of creating an inclusive and supportive environment in higher education, particularly in clinical programs like CSD.

¹ According to the Sensory Safe team, using Autistic with a capital "A" is a way to show respect for Autistic individuals and celebrate their unique strengths and perspectives. It helps move away from the old-school medicalized language that used to be used to describe Autism (Weldings, 2023)

Literature Review/Background

Terminology and landscape of neurodiversity

The purpose of this study is to explore the experience of neurodivergent individuals in Communication Sciences and Disorders (CSD) programs as expressed via *Reddit*, a popular social media platform. *Neurodivergent* is a term used to refer to people with neurological functioning that differ substantially from societal norms and expectations. The term aligns with the neurodiversity paradigm, which frames cognitive differences as a form of diversity. Specifically, neurodiversity refers to "neurological variations regarding learning, communication, sociability, attention, mood and other mental functions" (Conditt, 2020). Such neurological differences can be seen in individuals with dyspraxia, dyslexia, Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), dyscalculia, autism, Tourette syndrome, and other conditions. Although the neurodiversity umbrella is broad, the Neurodiversity Movement was established by Autistic individuals, and much of the related ideas and cultural content centers Autistic voices. The Neurodiversity movement emerged in the 1990s, fuelled by the explosion of the internet, and reframed autism and other neurocognitive differences as legitimate ways of being rather than disordered (Silberman, 2017). Instead of fixing neurodivergent minds and focusing on perceived deficits, the neurodiversity paradigm reframes autism as a form neurotypical difference that is worthy of societal acceptance and accommodation (Angulo-Jiménez & DeThorne, 2019; Milton, 2020). Social media maintains a prominent role within the neurodivergent community and culture, with *Reddit* in particular, serving as a significant platform.

As important context from the Neurodiversity Movement, the medical paradigm has been the dominant Western approach to defining and treating autism since the diagnosis

was first presented in 1944 (Kanner, 1944). Medicalized approaches focus on the perceived shortcomings and deficits of neurodivergent people. Although the medical diagnostic criteria for autism has changed over time, the focus on perceived impairment in social communication has remained relatively constant (Zeldovich, 2018). The current diagnostic manual for psychology defines autism spectrum disorder as “persistent difficulties with social communication and social interaction” and “restricted and repetitive patterns of behaviours, activities or interests” (this includes sensory behaviour), present since early childhood, to the extent that these “limit and impair everyday functioning” (American Psychiatric Association, 2013). This definition has been used as the cornerstone of many allied health disciplines, including communication sciences and disorders (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association, *n.d.*). This medicalized perspective has been fundamental in the diagnosis of autism, the documentation of increasing prevalence rates (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2023) over time, and the nature of support services that are provided to autistic people across the lifespan, including college-based experiences.

Autistic Experience and College

According to a 2022 survey of 54,000 undergraduate college students conducted by the American College Health Association (ACHA), 15% of undergraduate students reported having ADHD and 3% of students identified as Autistic. Research has shown that 34.7% of Autistic individuals attend college within six years of graduating high school (Shattuck, 2012), and the rate is likely higher given the increase autism diagnoses over recent year (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2023). College is a critical time for students, both due to the increased opportunities for agency and self-determination during early adulthood and

the critical transition in disability support service, mechanisms. Specifically, disability supports provided by Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) are no longer relevant after high school and legal rights under the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) become more prominent (Arky, 2023). Studies have shown that Autistic students experience various challenges during college, which include access to accommodations, difficulty addressing sensory needs, prominent feelings of self-doubt, and various concerns with mental health (Gurbuz, Hanley, & Riby, 2019). Additionally, many students struggle to access the services and supports needed to succeed in college (Austermann, 2023) Despite this emergent literature, limited scientific studies have focused on Autistic collegiate experiences within allied health fields in general, and CSD specifically. Despite this gap in the professional literature, Autistic SLPs have documented their personal experience through blogs and other online platforms.

The reported experiences of Autistic SLPs within CSD programs are not particularly surprising given the medicalized framework. Based on a history of the field published online (Duchan, n.d.), the field of speech language pathology emerged in the late 19th and early 20th centuries from influences in linguistics, psychology, medicine, and education. Initially, speech correctionists and elocutionists addressed speech sound disorders, however the understanding of the field deepened with the advancements in neurology and otolaryngology. The field evolved into a more scientific and medical profession and the American Speech Language Hearing Association (ASHA) was founded in 1925. However, it remained focused on “correcting” deviations from a communication standard that was largely defined by White Western cultural values (Abrahams et al., 2019, St. Pierre & St. Pierre, 2018; Yu et al., 2021). Based on this history, it is not surprising that current practitioners in the field are primarily White, female, non-autistic, and nondisabled

(American Speech-Language-Hearing Association, 2022), which can perpetuate harmful practices that disproportionately impact marginalized communities because treatment and assessments are often viewed through a narrow lens influenced by the lived experiences and cultural perspectives of this dominant group (Crosbie, 2022).

Although few in number, Autistic SLPs are increasingly raising awareness in the field, both of their own experiences and their unique perspectives on the field, by actively advocating for greater acceptance and accommodation of neurodiversity within the profession (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association, 2020). Because of the important role of neurodivergent SLPs in dismantling ableism within field, understanding what barriers and supports they experience in CSD programs is critical. Consequently, the aim of the current study is to bring some of the prominent neurodivergent and Autistic student experiences expressed on social media into scientific inquiry and dissemination.

The specific research question is:

What are the lived experiences of neurodivergent students in CSD programs as expressed via Reddit?

Method

Participants/Data Source

This study relied on existing publicly available data through posts on Reddit, a discussion-based social media platform with various channels dedicated to specific topics or groups. Reddit was selected based on its prominence as a social media platform; it was recently cited as the seventh most visited website in the country (Jacques et al., 2023). In addition, its structure allows for the creation of sub-reddits dedicated to specific intersectional identities and niche experiences that provide a valuable opportunity to explore neurodivergent experiences within SLP communities. We focused on analysing existing data from *Reddit*, specifically from a channel related to SLPs. Using the *Reddit* search function, we searched “SLP” and filtered results to show communities, also known as subreddits. We selected the first channel listed (r/SLP) which had the largest number of members (54.1K members). Within this channel, we used search terms such as “neurodivergent” and selected the first ten posts that were relevant and met our criteria. For reliability, another committee member, Dr. DeThorne, independently repeated the process and we compared our lists to ensure consistency. We decided to focus on 10 posts, along with their comments to keep our data manageable and allow for qualitative analysis.

All relevant posts were collected in a single Excel spreadsheet saved in OneDrive and each post was assigned a unique coded identifier (e.g., P1, P2, P3) and included information such as the account name, channel, original Reddit post, and link to the specific sub-reddit (i.e., comments, responses). Once collected, the content of these posts (both original Reddit post and comments) were added into the software program Atlas.ti for qualitative analysis. We employed a thematic analysis broadly based on the framework outlined in Braun and Clark (2006) to derive key inductive categories and themes. We analysed the selected posts and their comments by coding individual statements, which ranged from single sentences to paragraphs. We identified 180 statements which were categorized into 11 codes. Additionally, a statement could be assigned multiple codes if it addressed more than one concept. From the 11 codes, we created four overarching themes.

Inclusion criteria

Specified inclusionary criteria for posts were a) primarily written in English within the last ten years, b) representative of first-person neurodivergent perspective (i.e., "own voice"), either as specified in the channel itself or the text of the post itself, and c) reference to college experience in Communication Sciences & Disorders (e.g., audiology, speech-language pathology). Although our primary focus was on student perspectives, we also gathered insightful viewpoints from neurodivergent practitioners, which were incorporated into the study, as their experiences mirrored the students' and provided additional insights and valuable information.

Consent and ethical considerations

The study underwent review and approval by the *Institutional Review Board* (IRB) to ensure ethical compliance. Since the data were collected from *Reddit*, an open-access online

platform, the study qualified as exempt under the IRB guidelines. As such, consent was not requested from participants due to the public nature of the data (Lauterwasser & Nedzhvetskaya, 2023). Names and other identifying information were anonymized to protect the identity of participants in this research and ensure confidentiality.

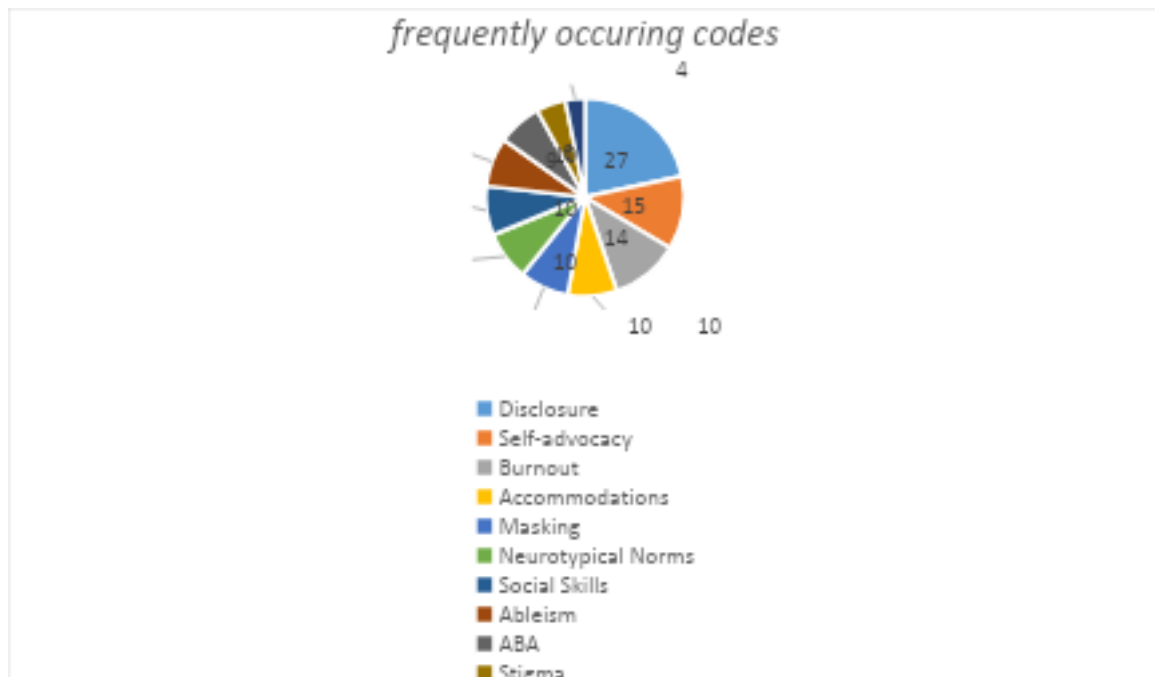
Positionality statement

In conducting this research, I acknowledge that my background, experiences and perspectives may influence the lens through which I approach this topic. I have taken deliberate steps to ensure that this research is approached with transparency, being mindful of how my own viewpoints could impact my data collection, analysis, and interpretation. I collaborated with my committee members throughout the data collection and analysis process to minimize potential biases. This collaboration also served to validate the consistency and transparency of the results.

Research findings

This study explored the experiences of neurodivergent individuals in higher education, specifically, the Communication and Sciences Disorders field (CSD). The data was analysed by generating codes that reflect recurring patterns, which were then grouped into broader themes. A total of 10 posts, along with their associated comments were analysed for the study. From this analysis, 29 codes were identified and used to develop four broader themes.

The chart below showcases the relative proportions of the frequently occurring codes.



Total number of statements = 180

Theme 1: Disclosure

Many neurodivergent students discussed the challenge of deciding whether to disclose their condition to professors, peers, or administrators. For some, disclosure was a necessary step to receive accommodations and support, while others feared stigma or discrimination. Participants highlighted the key aspects of their experiences, with disclosure and masking being the most frequently mentioned theme, accounting for 20.56% of total statements coded. Some participants expressed a reluctance to share this information stating: “I have a few diagnoses that I choose not to disclose professionally. In my personal experience, I’ve found many people just haven’t evolved into open, accepting, compassionate human beings. I protect myself above all else.” Another participant’s

response to whether one should disclose their disability or not was “No, please don't, or at least be very cautious about whom you come out to.”

Others supported the idea of openly disclosing their neurodivergence, with one participant stating: “I have ADHD and Narcolepsy, and I typically disclose my disabilities to my employers to let them know why I might need certain accommodations. They are usually treated like no big deal. I disclose to clients, their families, and coworkers when I feel it is relevant and helpful.”

One participant noted that although they don't conceal their neurodivergent identity, they also don't openly disclose it. They shared: “I am open about who I am. I don't advertise my autism, but I don't hide it either. Most colleagues figure it out or suspect it before I tell them.” A practicing Autistic speech-language pathologist supported this perspective, explaining that they “share when it's relevant (to work or the conversation at hand), but don't disclose randomly.”

The decision to disclose is deeply personal and can significantly affect the student's experience in the program, often weighing the benefits of support against the potential for bias or misunderstanding. One of the coping strategies discussed was masking, which involves concealing one's neurodivergent traits to conform to neurotypical expectations. Many participants expressed how masking leaves them emotionally exhausted, and depending on the environment, disclosing one's neurodivergent identity may not always feel safe, further complicating the issue. A participant shared: “I haven't told colleagues I'm autistic because I can't face the reactions “you're not, you're so [insert choice of observable behaviours as a result of heavy masking].”

One participant stated: “I am fairly transparent even when all my energy is put into masking and controlling how I move, use my eyes and hands, process information, and talk to others.” Another added “Like you will not see me out there targeting eye contact and it pains me because I more or less taught myself to mask socially (and the effects) and I don’t want to bring that on impressionable students.”

Disclosure and masking are significant factors in the experiences of neurodivergent experiences. The decision to disclose one neurodivergence is a personal choice influenced by finding the balance between seeking support and the potential risks and stigma associated with the decision.

Theme 2: Social interactions and neurodiversity

One of the key themes that emerged from our analysis is social interactions and neurodiversity. Contributing codes to this theme included difficulties with social interactions, experiences of burnout and stress.

Participants noted that social interactions with colleagues, professors, and clients have been challenging. 16% of the statements coded were associated with this theme, including aspects of neurotypical norms, and social dynamics. One participant described: “I don’t partake in social events outside of work and often spend my weekends stimming and reading in solitude.” Another participant shared that “it’s hard to pick up on what a client is not doing correctly socially, and it’s hard to model good social pragmatic skills- they’re sometimes not concepts that I myself have mastered.”

Social interactions emerged as a significant theme, with participants highlighting the challenges navigating social dynamics and the pressure to conform to neurotypical norms, which often leads to high levels of burnout and stress.

Theme 3: Disabilities, challenges and therapeutic approaches

This theme looked at how societal expectations and practices affect individuals' experiences and neurodivergent identities. The codes contributing to this theme included *ableism* (discrimination against people with disabilities), ABA (a therapy aimed at modifying behaviour to align with neurotypical standards) and *neurotypical norms* (societal pressure to conform to behaviours that are considered "normal"). Out of the 180 total statements, 6% reflected individuals' concerns about ableism in the field and the controversy surrounding ABA approaches. Some of these challenges arise from societal expectations, while others stem from obstacles faced by neurodivergent individuals.

An Autistic participant commented about the challenges of educating others because of the misconceptions people have about Autism, stating, "It's tiring trying to teach others about neurodiversity affirming concepts and I have been getting push back from some special ed teachers who use a lot of ABA/behavioralism concepts in their classrooms". Other participants have shared their challenges, with one stating, "Sometimes I just want to grab my colleagues by the shoulders and yell "you're not a better person than me." Additionally, the demands of academic and clinical work can be intense and overwhelming, leading to challenges with task management. Transitioning between activities, multitasking, and managing the complexities of a caseload can be overwhelming without adequate support systems in place. A participant reported, "In my experience, I struggle most with executive functioning, sensory integration, and some pragmatics. In school I struggled with

organization, planning, and initiation/motivation.” Finally, a participant stated, “I never even realized how difficult eye contact was for me until grad school when my supervisor noted it, and it shocked me.” These comments reflect the growing concerns neurodivergent students and professionals have with ableism in the field of CSD.

Ethical concerns are a critical consideration when working with neurodivergent clients, particularly in fields like Communication Sciences and Disorders. Participants in this research highlighted several issues like struggling with teaching and modelling skills they personally find challenging. For example, a neurodivergent clinician might face ethical dilemmas when asked to teach skills they don’t naturally embody, such as maintaining eye contact or specific social behaviours. One participant shared: “it's hard to pick up on what a client is not doing correctly socially, and it's hard to model good social pragmatic skills- they're sometimes not concepts that I myself have mastered.” Others, have shared ethical concerns about certain practices, like ABA, that don’t align with their beliefs and values. This raises questions about authenticity, self-advocacy, and the ethical responsibilities of practitioners.

Theme 4: Advocacy and support

The topic of advocacy and self-advocacy were frequently mentioned by participants, accounting for 5% and 8% of total codes, respectively. There was a clear need for stronger systems in place that not only allow students to advocate for themselves but also encourage faculty and institutions to take a more proactive role in supporting neurodivergent students.

Having a strong support system and being surrounded by people who embrace the neurodivergent identity plays a crucial role in one's performance as a practitioner. Many reported that having a supportive system helped them navigate their journey. A CSD student stated: "This semester I'm taking a class on ASD and thankfully our professor is accepting of individuals with ASD and is helping to correct some misconceptions about it."

Another participant emphasized the importance of normalizing discussions about neurodivergent practitioners, stating, "I personally believe that the more we're out and about it, the more normalized and less "marked" we're going to be and the easier it will be in general for us and the rest of the world."

One participant expressed the positive impact of having a supportive network, saying, "for the first time in my life, I'm finally being provided with kindness and support rather than criticism and disdain for my differences - one of my professors even showed me a private space in the building that I can go to pace and rock when I need to."

The analysis revealed several broad themes that highlight the neurodivergent experiences in higher education in CSD programs. The four themes are deeply interconnected. The decision of disclosing one's neurodivergent identity is often influenced by the presence of ableism and discrimination which may impact one's ability to socially interact with their peers and others. This may lead to individuals feeling pressured to mask and hide their neurodivergent identity to "fit in" and conform to society's neurotypical standards. These challenges were not exclusive to neurodivergent students; neurodivergent practitioners also reported similar challenges which led us to incorporate their perspectives in our analysis." These experiences emphasize the need for advocacy and support to help

neurodivergent individuals be their true selves and challenge ableism and societal pressure to conform to normalcy.

Conclusion

Neurodiversity is a term used to describe the wide range of human brains including individuals who have neurological differences such as Autism, Dyslexia, Schizophrenia, ADHD and other neurological conditions. Due to the different neurological structure of the neurodivergent brain, performing tasks in the way that is designed for neurotypical brains can be particularly challenging. Expectations and rules that are predominantly designed for neurotypical brains can limit the potential of neurodivergent people.

Some of the challenges that neurodivergent students may encounter in higher education settings are the social interactions with instructors and peers. The neurodivergent brain processes information differently, requiring unique approaches to navigating tasks. A common struggle that many participants shared is the ability transitioning between activities, multitasking and managing full caseloads without adequate support. Additionally, sensitivities around sensory input, executive function and the constant demand to “mask” their identity often leaves neurodivergent individuals feeling drained and burnt out.

Another pressing concern for neurodivergent individuals in both educational and clinical setting, is navigating their roles while working with neurodivergent clients. Some participants shared the difficulty of teaching skills that they themselves struggle with. One participant shared: “I think that it will be hard if I ever want to work with pragmatics

because I struggle with pragmatics myself". Another added: "it's hard to model good social pragmatic skills- they're sometimes not concepts that I myself have mastered".

Ethical concerns about therapy approaches, particularly Applied Behavioural Analysis (ABA) were also highlighted. A participant shared "I have a lot of ethical concerns with well, everything, and I often feel like a bystander who is not doing enough to be neurodivergent affirming even though I myself am autistic." Many of those concerns revolve around aba and ableism. The controversy surrounding ABA stems from the concerns about its approach in conforming and modifying behaviours in neurodivergent individuals rather than embracing the neurodiversity and individuality of those individuals (Hollander, 2023). The field of speech and hearing sciences has evolved significantly over the years, promoting evidence-based practices and moving toward an inclusive and neurodiversity affirming approach in practices, however this has not always been the case. The field has a complex history and foundation is rooted in ableism, often focusing on "fixing" speech behaviours to be more normative. While progress is being made, the concept of neurodiversity affirming care is still relatively new. The neurotypical norms and societal expectations are still imposed on neurodivergent students in higher education settings resulting in challenges and barriers to accessible and equal opportunities for success.

A major challenge that neurodivergent students face in college is the process of seeking accommodations. Unlike the K-12 educational system where Individualized Education Programs (IEPs) automatically provide support and roll with the student, the responsibility in college entirely shifts to the student seeking out services and advocating for accommodations and considerations (Parker Harris, Gould, & Mullin, 2019). This can leave students feeling unsupported and unprepared. Many participants encouraged seeking out

accommodations and shared their positive experiences on *Reddit*. A CSD student shared that receiving accommodations from their professors has been really helpful, stating: “Speaking as a neurodiverse SLP student finishing grad school, disclosing my ADHD to my peers/receiving accommodations from my professors has been really helpful for me.” Additionally, practitioners in the field supported the idea by sharing their experiences of asking for accommodations at the workplace.

One of the major barriers to disclosing one’s neurodivergent identity is ongoing struggle with ableism. A participant shared: “It really is a difficult fight unfortunately, and at my first placement I was actively discriminated against although the only thing I told them was that I had “difficulties with social/pragmatic communication.” Another participant added: “ all the people who told me that I can't be an SLP because I'm autistic.” It is no wonder that individuals may feel hesitant to disclose their neurodivergent identity, given the mixed reactions often received from others.

Sensitivity and discomfort surrounding discussions about neurodivergence remain prevalent. The term *allistic fragility* has been coined to describe the discomfort allistic individuals may feel when confronted with the unique communication styles and social differences of their autistic counterparts, or their prior beliefs about autism are (Hanks, 2023).

Having a strong support system and being surrounded by people who embrace the neurodivergent identity plays a crucial role in one’s performance as a practitioner. Many participants reported that professors and supervisors have been increasingly open to learning how to better support them, with one stating: “For the first time in my life, I’m finally being provided with kindness and support rather than criticism and disdain for my

differences - one of my professors even showed me a private space in the building that I can go to pace and rock when I need to. They are explicit in their communication with me and committed to helping me interpret the unwritten and hidden social communication that underlies academia.” Additionally, neurodivergent individuals in the field have been self-advocating for themselves and standing up for their clients whom may share similar identities. Many neurodivergent individuals have found untraditional ways to support their clients, whether it was sharing their personal experience and relating to the clients or helping them embrace their differences and amplify their voices.

This topic remains relatively new but it is important further explore the experiences of neurodivergent individuals in CSD fields. Future research should focus on strategies for instructors and peers to better understand and support neurodivergent students in their journey to becoming practitioners as well as bridging the gaps that exist between neurotypical students and neurodivergent students in the field. It is important to recognize that the experiences of one neurodivergent individual does not represent all neurodivergent individuals.

Limitations

While this study provides valuable insights, it is limited by its reliance on self-reported data, which may be subject to bias. Additionally, the sample may not be fully representative of all neurodivergent individuals.

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